

Reconsidering the Necessity of Partisanship in Mass Polarization

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Draft: September 7, 2026

Abstract

Mass polarization is often considered a partisan phenomenon, but is partisanship a necessary condition for mass polarization? To answer this question, we examine whether policy disagreement, specifically opinion divergence, can contribute to affective polarization independently of partisanship. We test three theoretical and empirical premises of partisan-centric accounts relating to opinion divergence. First, we test whether opinion divergence has remained stable, as previous conclusions of stability were instrumental in leading subsequent theories to de-center policy disagreement and prioritize partisanship. Using the Wasserstein Bipolarization Index that axiomatizes the distributional intuitions of bipolarization, we find increasing opinion divergence in the general electorate contrary to previous findings. Second, we test whether this increase extends beyond partisans by examining non-leaning Independents, whom partisan-centric models assume remain centrist over time. We find that non-leaners diverge comparably to weak partisans and leaning Independents, demonstrating that opinion divergence is not confined to the partisan framework. Third, to confirm that non-leaners' policy opinions have affective consequences, we examine whether they are associated with affective differentiation based on agreement or disagreement and find a positive and growing correlation. Together, these findings provide evidence consistent with opinion divergence operating as a path to affective polarization independently of partisan identity. To reconcile this pathway with existing partisan-centric models, we propose a *substantive-identity dual model* of polarization.

Keywords: Opinion Polarization, Partisan Sorting, Wasserstein Distance, Public Opinion.

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